



A still from *Do Bigha Zameen*



Q: Where was Bimal Roy born?

A: Dhaka, now in Bangladesh

Q: Which documentary of his was praised for its "plastic and moral beauty" at the Cannes in 1956?

A: *Gotama the Buddha*

Q: What was the name of his feature film debut?

A: *Udayar Pathay*, 1944

Q: Who gave him first break in filmmaking and as what?

A: P.C. Barua, as a publicity photographer

Q: Which song of *Madhumati*, which inspired *Om Shanti Om*, was initially rejected by Roy?

A: *Aaja re pardeesi*, music by Salil Chowdhury, sung by Lata Mangeshkar

when he passed away. What started as a project on his undisclosed movie clips became a journey for me to discover what my father's cinema was all about—the implacability of suffering and the universality of human emotions.

To understand his cinema, it is important to understand his background. Coming from a zamindar family he was dispossessed when his family was cheated on, and hence was left with just one obsession—making films. I often wonder why people call him a landmark filmmaker of the 1960s—his career actually started way back in 1932, when he was a film photographer. It was then that he started transporting his emotions into his creations, something that is very vividly seen in his movies. I think when one sees *Do Bigha Zameen*, it is his personal experience of injustice that seeps

through to give such an evocative creation to his audience.

He never thought about the market or audience. I remember one instance—even though I was just nine—during *Bandini*, when the producers wanted a befitting end where *Bandini* would go to the right man, whom she loved, to cater to popular tastes. My father was aghast. He said to my mother, "How can *Bandini* go to a person for whom she had murdered?" It didn't match his worldview. His films were his honest efforts and showed exactly what he thought and felt.

There were no material privileges in belonging to the Roy household. My father was concerned more with how we would evolve into responsible human beings. Our home was stark with only the basic necessities. He used all his resources for films. We lived in a rented

accommodation all along but travelled the world through the films, music and books that our parents brought home.

It was his quest for perfection that took up his energy and time. I remember how one early morning I saw my father sitting quietly near one of the windows at home. When I went near him, I was shushed. Several mornings went by but finally my curiosity got the better of me. It was then that he showed me how he was recording the sound of a *koel* (cuckoo) for a sequence in a movie. He wanted the exact sound of the early morning cooing and wouldn't settle for less. It was such attention to detail that perhaps keeps his work so relevant even today.

as told to **Bushra Ahmed**

The author is Bimal Roy's son and made the documentary *Remembering Bimal Roy*